

Silence in the City

With trenchant black humour and clever wordplay, this cinematic Calcutta novel explores the pathos of fame and failure



THE BIOSCOPE MAN
by INDRAJIT HAZRA
Penguin
Price: Rs 299
Pages: 320

■ By Brinda Bose

Parde ke peechey kya hai? What lies behind the screen?—journalist and novelist Indrajit Hazra's *The Bioscope Man* sneaks us adroitly past the cameras of the silent film industry and exposes with a wacky and trenchant black humour the bathos, the pathos and the incredible magic of the moving image in the heart of Bengali-land about a hundred years ago. There is no denying that Hazra's third novel is as much a paean to Calcutta as it is to cinema, but refreshingly, it is never sentimental, crisscrossed as it is continually by an incisive, rigorous irony of vision and verbal play that serves to remind us that the city, somewhat like the pictures that it throws up on celluloid, is at least partially what we make of it—or make up about it.

This inscrutable, irrefutable connection between the city and its cinema is explored through the story of Abani Chatterjee—a stage-turned-film-actor who wrestles with the neb-

ulous fame of superstardom and the overreaching ambition it inevitably fuels—in the freshly-fangled world of the bioscope in late colonial Bengal. Not entirely surprisingly, Abani is felled by the fickle forces of fate and fortune that do not heed the graces of his success, even as Calcutta reels under its own imminent loss of face with the moving of the colonialists' capital to Delhi. Mistiming—Hazra seems to cackle—is all that is needed to strip you of your crowded accomplishments in one fell swoop.

Woe is doubled—and mishap a certainty—if your moment of truth features a female, and tripled if the female is a 'mem': this is a truth universally acknowledged through generations of colonial encounters. And so it was with Abani's father

Tarini, his Shombhu-mama who introduced him to the fledgling film industry, and with Abani himself, who lost his paradise when he stumbled into a ladies' washroom in a drunken stupor to fall upon the astonished body of the same Adela who had been his father's undoing many decades ago, when he had unwittingly ungorged an undigested samosa-and tea meal upon her girlish dress-front in the first-class compartment of a train, and utterly ruined his own promising career.

That this Adela Heaslop, nee Qusted, is ghosted from Forster's *A Passage to India* is only one of the many cunning intellectual jokes Hazra rolls out for our added entertainment—some inter-textual, some historical, and a great many linguistic. The best one of all is the arrival of German filmmaker Fritz Lang in Calcutta to make a film on the Orientalist Sir William Jones, in which Abani is to be cast in a minor role of Jones' Sanskrit tutor Ramlochan Sharma. In a delightful postcolonial pirouette, Abani convinces Lang to make the Sanskrit pundit the central protagonist of a re-visualised film, to be renamed 'The Pandit and the Englishman'. *The Bioscope Man* is at once an engaging exploration of individual fame and failure in a fickle field such as film-acting, and a clever critique of Orientalist fixations.

Hazra has fashioned here a winsome, cinematic Calcutta novel that is charming in its inventiveness, if a trifle linguistically overwrought in parts. ■



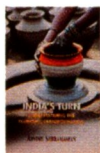
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